

# Email Infrastructure Runbook

Set up on **day 1**, because the clock starts the moment domains are registered and nothing else in the plan can move until it has run.

Two hard waits stack: Microsoft enforces a **14-day minimum domain age**, and warmup takes **~30 days** to reach full volume. Register the domains before you do anything else, even if you have not settled the brand name — sending domains are deliberately not the brand domain (§1).

Non-compliant mail is now **rejected at the receiving server**, not filtered into spam. Everything below is a condition of delivery, not an optimisation.

## 1. Domain plan

Nine domains, all registered to **Glass House Gardens Inc.**, all bought on the same day so the 14-day aging clock runs in parallel.

### Brand domain — never sends cold mail

| Domain           | Use                                        |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| shortlistaio.com | Website, client email, invoices, contracts |

Subdomains of it are fine for things that do not send outbound: `app.shortlistaio.com` (client dashboard), `reports.shortlistaio.com` (hosted reports), `research.shortlistaio.com` (the published Citation Index).

### Sending domains — eight separate registrations

| Domain               | Mailboxes |
|----------------------|-----------|
| getshortlistaio.com  | 2         |
| tryshortlistaio.com  | 2         |
| useshortlistaio.com  | 2         |
| goshortlistaio.com   | 2         |
| joinshortlistaio.com | 2         |
| withshortlistaio.com | 2         |
| shortlistaiohq.com   | 2         |
| shortlistaioteam.com | 2         |

**Separate registrations, not subdomains.** Reputation and DMARC alignment attach to the registered domain. `getshortlistaio.com` and `shortlistaio.com` are unrelated senders to Gmail and Outlook — the shared letters mean nothing to a filter — so a complaint spike on one cannot reach the other. A subdomain like

mail.shortlistaio.com rolls up to the same organisational domain and would carry the damage straight to the brand.

The shared name is deliberate. Filters ignore it; humans do not. Mail from getshortlistaio.com landing beside a site at shortlistaio.com reads as coherent, where mail from outreach-pro-42.com reads as exactly what it is.

## Sizing

| Step                                              | Figure                         |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Target volume                                     | 3,000 / month                  |
| ÷ 22 working days                                 | ~150 / day                     |
| ÷ 15 per mailbox per day (safe sustained rate)    | 10 mailboxes minimum           |
| ÷ 2 mailboxes per domain (more concentrates risk) | 5 domains minimum              |
| + headroom to rest a bad domain                   | <b>8 domains, 16 mailboxes</b> |

$16 \times 15 = 240/\text{day}$  capacity against 150/day needed. That headroom is the point: when a domain's placement drops you rest it for two weeks rather than pushing its volume onto the others and spreading the damage.

**Avoid** mail, inbox, outreach, crm, or digits in a sending domain — those read as disposable infrastructure to filters and humans alike.

## A note on topical neutrality

A sending domain must not carry a trading name that signals a category unrelated to the recipient's. **Shortlist AIO satisfies this by construction** — "shortlist" is the vocabulary of B2B software buying and describes precisely what the product does, so the brand can appear in the sending domains.

Keep the rule in mind if the trading name ever changes. A name drawn from a heavily filtered category — nutrition, supplements, finance, pharma — would have to be kept out of sending domains entirely, because it fails twice over: spam classifiers trained hard on that vocabulary, and a human who sees no topical relevance. Reply rate is the most sensitive variable in the financial model; one point of it is worth roughly 22% of Year-1 revenue.

**Never send cold outbound from the primary domain.** A complaint spike burns the sending domain's reputation. If that domain is also where your invoices, contracts, and client correspondence live, you lose the business's ability to send email at all. Sending domains are consumable; the brand domain is not.

Register **8 sending domains**, 2 mailboxes each = 16 mailboxes. At a conservative 15/day per mailbox that is 240/day capacity, comfortably above the 150/day steady state the plan assumes, leaving headroom to rest any domain that starts underperforming.

Buy .com where possible. Keep them at one registrar, on auto-renew, with WHOIS privacy on.

## 2. DNS records — per sending domain

Replace example.com with the domain and the selector/values your mailbox provider gives you.

## SPF — one record only

```
Type: TXT    Host: @    Value: v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ~all
```

**Exactly one SPF record per domain.** Two records is a permanent failure, not a warning. Use ~all (softfail) during warmup; move to -all once stable. Keep total DNS lookups at **10 or fewer** — each include: counts.

## DKIM — generated by the mailbox provider

```
Type: TXT    Host: [selector]._domainkey    Value: v=DKIM1; k=rsa; p=[LONG PUBLIC KEY]
```

Use **2048-bit** keys. Copy the value exactly — a single truncated character silently breaks signing.

## DMARC — start at none, then tighten

```
Type: TXT    Host: _dmarc    Value: v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc@[brand].com; fo=1; adkim=r; aspf=r
```

Start at p=none and **read the aggregate reports for two weeks** before tightening. Moving straight to p=reject on a misconfigured domain silently blackholes your own mail.

Progression: p=none → p=quarantine; pct=25 → p=quarantine → p=reject. Only advance when reports show 100% alignment.

**Alignment is what actually matters.** SPF and DKIM must not merely pass — they must pass *for the domain in the From header*. A relay that passes SPF for its own domain fails alignment and fails DMARC.

## MX and tracking

MX per your mailbox provider. If your sequencer offers a custom tracking domain, use a subdomain of the **sending** domain, never the brand domain.

## 3. Mailbox setup

- **2 mailboxes per domain**, real human names, not info@ or sales@.
- Set a **real display name, signature, and profile photo** on each. Empty

profiles correlate with filtering.

- Every signature carries the **Manitoba registered office postal address**

(CAN-SPAM §4 of the compliance policy) and a working unsubscribe.

- Enable the provider's warmup pool if available; otherwise use the

sequencer's.

## 4. Warmup schedule

Do not compress this. It is the cheapest insurance in the business.

| Days  | Per mailbox / day | Notes                                |
|-------|-------------------|--------------------------------------|
| 1–14  | 0 real sends      | Domain aging. Warmup pool only.      |
| 15–21 | 5                 | First real sends. Watch bounce rate. |
| 22–28 | 10                |                                      |
| 29–35 | 15                | Approaching steady state             |
| 36+   | 15 (cap)          | 16 mailboxes ≈ 240/day capacity      |

**Never exceed 200/day on a new domain.** Ramp per mailbox, not per domain.

## 5. Health thresholds — stop-the-line numbers

| Metric                     | Healthy           | Action                                                                    |
|----------------------------|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Spam complaint rate</b> | <b>&lt; 0.10%</b> | <b>Stop sending.</b> 0.30% triggers enforcement.                          |
| Bounce rate                | < 2%              | > 5% — stop, re-verify the list                                           |
| Open rate                  | > 35%             | < 20% — placement problem, pause and test                                 |
| Reply rate                 | > 3%              | < 2% for two months — offer or vertical problem, not a deliverability one |

Check weekly. Postmaster tools: Google Postmaster Tools and Microsoft SNDS — register every sending domain with both on day 1.

## 6. Pre-send checklist

Run before the first real send on any domain, and after any DNS change.

- ☐ Exactly one SPF record; passes; ≤ 10 lookups
- ☐ DKIM signs and verifies; 2048-bit
- ☐ DMARC present; **SPF and DKIM both align** with the From domain
- ☐ Domain ≥ 14 days old
- ☐ Warmup run ≥ 14 days
- ☐ Mailbox has display name, signature, photo
- ☐ Signature carries the Manitoba postal address and unsubscribe
- ☐ Registered with Google Postmaster Tools and Microsoft SNDS
- ☐ Suppression list connected and checked at send time
- ☐ **Country screen active — US recipients only** (legal/CASL-screening-procedure.md §3)
- ☐ Domain not on a public blocklist

Verify with a seed-list test to Gmail, Outlook, and Yahoo addresses, plus a tool such as mail-tester.com. **Confirm placement, not just delivery** — mail that lands in Promotions or Junk is delivered and worthless.

## 7. Costs

| Item                            | Cost                           |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 8 sending domains               | ~\$96 / yr                     |
| Brand domain shortlistaio.com   | ~\$15 / yr                     |
| 16 mailboxes                    | ~\$40 / mo                     |
| Sequencer (unlimited mailboxes) | \$39 / mo                      |
| <b>Running total</b>            | <b>~\$79 / mo + \$111 / yr</b> |

Within the plan's \$1,000 opening budget, which allocates \$110 for domains, \$75 for three months of mailboxes, and \$117 for three months of sequencer.

## 8. When something breaks

**Sudden placement drop** — check DNS first (a registrar change or an expired record), then recent copy changes, then complaint rate. Pause the affected domain; do not spread the volume across the others, which propagates the problem.

**One domain underperforming** — rest it for 2 weeks on warmup only. This is why 8 domains exist rather than 3.

**All domains underperforming** — the problem is the message or the list, not the infrastructure. Stop and fix that; more domains will not help.